

Dmitriy Ivkov

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Historically, I have been a massive... massive... planner. Whether it was a daily to-do list, color-coded and updated on an almost hourly basis, or mapping out my entire week in advance, nitpicking and fine-tuning have dictated my life. In high school, I kept a binder where every assignment, extracurricular, and even casual meetups were cataloged down to the hour. In spite of this, when it came time to plan my friend's Europe trip, I was forced to cede control. Our group's decisions required everyone's input. For our trip, I was subject to my friends' sporadic, spontaneous choices for the itinerary. Initially, I feared their spontaneity, the endless trip mishaps and failures, but despite several homeless nights and missed trains, I realized that a trip can still meet its goals even without meticulous planning.

Our mishaps began while visiting France. Hasty assumptions caused us to miss the opportunity to visit the Louvre. We had foolishly assumed that, just because tickets had been available when we first checked, they would remain so. Ultimately, when it came time to buy tickets, we discovered they were sold out for the next several weeks, long after we would have returned to the States. I was distraught because my primary motivation for adding Paris to our itinerary had been its art museums, even though my friends disagreed. When I discovered the tickets' unavailability, my friends rejoiced over the opportunity to skip "yet another art museum." Despite my brooding, they dragged me across the city. And, in spite of the aimless wandering, we ended up at a restaurant, Le Petit Poucet, which happened to be the subject of Renoir's Luncheon of the Boating Party. There, I had the chance to try probably the most memorable dishes of my life: frog legs and escargot. Even after our lunch, further wandering brought us to the front steps of

the art museums Le Orangerie and Musée d'Orsay. Le Orangerie is famous for Monet's Water Lilies, wall-spanning panels that create a meditative space. Since it was not the Louvre and my friends were not particularly interested, they skipped attending while I explored. Despite my low expectations, I was overjoyed. Le Orangerie contained one of the largest Monet collections I had ever seen, so significant that several of these works had been referenced in my art history class. Seeing them in person revealed the scale, brushwork, and evolving palette that made Monet's Impressionism so revolutionary: a direct, immersive encounter that no lecture or reproduction could convey.



Fig. 1. Dmitriy Ivkov, A Selfie at the Running of the Bulls, Pamplona, Spain, July 2025. Personal photograph.

Subsequent tensions between failure and unexpected reward were restored in Pamplona. We arrived during San Fermín with only one full day allotted to the festivities, running with the bulls, and because of our perpetual lack of foresight, an early 4 a.m. start, an Airbnb far from the plaza, and buses that did not run until six: we missed our chance to run with the bulls. What was supposed to be the defining event of our visit degraded into frustration as we discovered how a

series of small oversights had compounded into a missed opportunity. While my friends chose to leave the city rather than scramble for housing or improvise a solution, I stubbornly stayed behind, unwilling to let the experience end so cleanly. I spent the night sleeping in the starting plaza itself, wrapped in the red pañuelo I had bought to complete a traditional Galician outfit, surrounded by the remnants of celebration and late party-goers from the “sleepless city.” In that moment, the neckerchief became more than an accessory: it became functional and symbolic, a source of warmth and a marker of persistence in the face of poor planning. I carried the pañuelo with me to all subsequent stops on our trip (France, Barcelona, and back to Pamplona) where, unfortunately, it continued to serve practical purposes: a clean place to sleep in times of Airbnb mishaps. What initially felt like a failure became one of the trip’s most vivid memories. Fantastic times and extraordinary trips don’t have to come from precision or control, but from perseverance and a willingness to remain present when plans go awry.

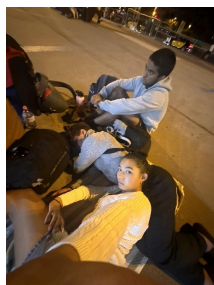


Fig. 2. Robyn Tonomura Macdonald, Friends sleeping at train station in Barcelona, Barcelona, Spain, July 2025. Personal photograph.

Another major mishap, entirely out of our control, occurred while trying to fly from Barcelona to Portugal. Terrible weather resulted in a flight cancellation and, subsequently, a train cancellation for the backup option. Our only choice was to wait out the storm. Once again, we ended up

sleeping in a train station, sprawled on hard floors and surrounded by the murmur of anxious travelers, the flicker of lights, and the occasional announcement over the PA system. The station offered little comfort beyond national news coverage and the occasional Red Cross volunteers. When the weather finally improved and we were able to take a train to Lisbon, we ended up stopping in Madrid. We hadn't planned on Madrid at all, and yet, because of the storm and our delay, it became an unexpected highlight of the trip. My only motivation had been the Museo del Prado, home to the massive collection of Goya's work I had been hoping to see. In the few hours we had, I sped through the museum, pausing only when a painting demanded it: the raw violence of Saturn Devouring His Son, the eerie, chaotic energy of Witches' Sabbath, the sorrow and defiance of The Third of May 1808. My friends wandered in and out of rooms, occasionally rolling their eyes at my obsession. The storm, the missed trains, and the unplanned detours didn't matter: I had stumbled into exactly what I had been hoping for. It reminded me, again, that the most wonderful parts of a trip rarely come from careful planning; they come from being willing to get lost, to endure discomfort, and to notice the unexpected moments that somehow turn into lasting memories.



Fig. 3. Dmitriy Ivkov, Sleeping friends in Madrid, Madrid, Spain, July 2025. Personal photograph.

In spite of our many mishaps, and the fact that I developed a personal method for sleeping on dirty, bedless floors, I found a way to love our trip. My favorite and most salient memories came from unexpected mistakes. Whether it was homeless nights in Pamplona, Barcelona, and Paris, or missed admission to the Louvre, my friends and I found ways to make the trip work and truly enjoy it. Over the course of the trip, I grew to accept that losing expectations and adaptively accepting the unexpected can really make a trip incredible

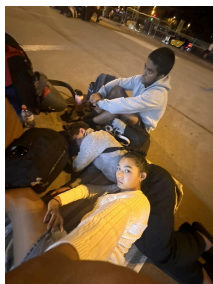
Works Cited



Ivkov, Dmitriy. *A Selfie at the Running of the Bulls*. July 2025. Personal photograph.



Ivkov, Dmitriy. *Sleeping Friends in Madrid*. July 2025. Personal photograph.



Tonomura-Macdonald, Robyn. *Friends Sleeping at Train Station in Barcelona*. July 2025.

Personal photograph.

Statement

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